Graphic Design

Packaging Design

Summary Notes

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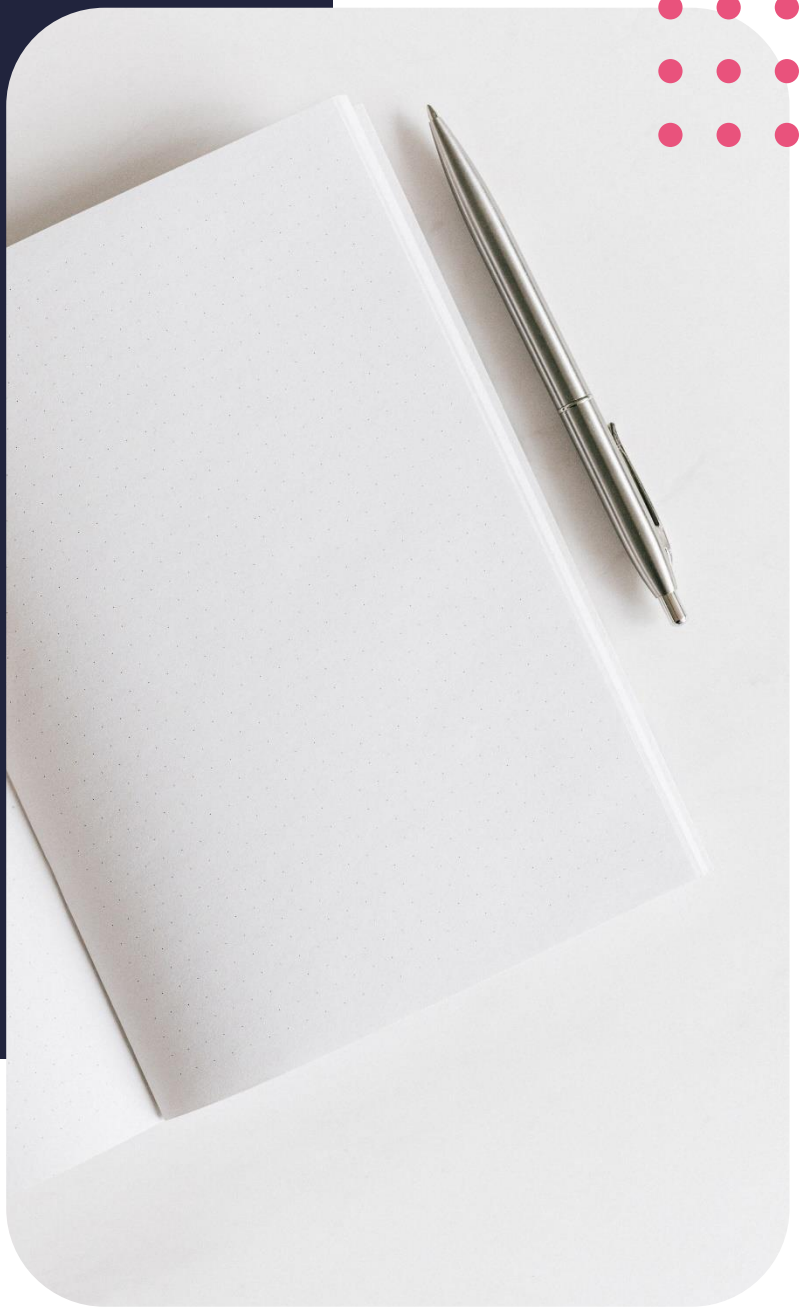


Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Lesson outcome 1: What is packaging design?
- Lesson outcome 2: Packaging design essential tips
- Lesson outcome 3: Most common type of packaging material
- Lesson outcome 4: Paperboard packaging demo

Introduction

Swedish design company, Tomorrow Machine created a magical juice box. Why magical? Well, the box withers at the same rate as the fresh juice inside of it does, since it is made of agar-agar seaweed gel and water only.

The sample on the far left here shows what the box looks like being left at room temperature for one day. The box on the far right has been left at room temperature for one month.

What is packaging design?

Packaging is created to contain, shield, transport, store, recognise and differentiate a product within the market.

Packaging design entails not only the form, structure and materials but also the design including use of colour, imagery as well as typography along with all other information and designs to make the product suitable for marketing and thus generating sales.

The ultimate goal of packaging design is to communicate the product's use and function and thus generating a sale from that.

It all started quite simple, but as the times changed and more competition entered the market, businesses had to do something to make their products stand out – and this is exactly where packaging design comes in.

Did you know that most consumers form an impression during the 1st seven seconds they see a product? Hence, if your product is contained in a package (which it might and should likely be), it is the first impression your customer will get – don't mess it up!

Packaging design essential tips

Understanding what packaging design is and entails, I would like to share with you some valuable tips on what to consider when you create packaging design as a graphic designer. A lot of these essentials link in with the general elements and principles of design so what you have learnt so far will simply be reiterated.

Can you recall the history we learned in previous lessons? If so, you might remember the name. Walter Gropius. Walter was the founder of the famous Bauhaus art school in Germany stated and he stated that *form should follow function.* This can be applied to design in general but how this is applied to packaging specifically is by focusing on the practicality of the package and once that is achieved, look at the aesthetics of your package. If any design is not practical, what is the use for it?

Clarity & simplicity links well with the functionality of your packaging design. Consider the effective use of your design elements and principles to ultimately form an effective visual hierarchy. Considering the packaging design for Canyon, the message is simple and clear. The use of elements and principles were applied successfully to create an effective visual hierarchy. Not needing to read much, you can instantly determine the type of product.

Honesty is one of the most important factors to consider. Does the packaging actually contain what your packaging design displays? Because we all know that what you see is not always what you get. This in turn will create or break customer loyalty.

At the heart of ***authenticity*** lies originality, character and memorability. It can be tricky to master because there are hundreds of products that you will compete with. You need to be original to stand out but still recognised for the product you're selling. There is not one specific way to achieve authenticity and it is not easy but effectively applying these essential tips should make your product stand out. Also, consider what you learnt in lesson 1 of module 3 when it comes to creative thinking. – if you can't remember, simply rewatch the lesson to stir your creative juices.

When I speak about ***shelf impact***, I don't mean this:

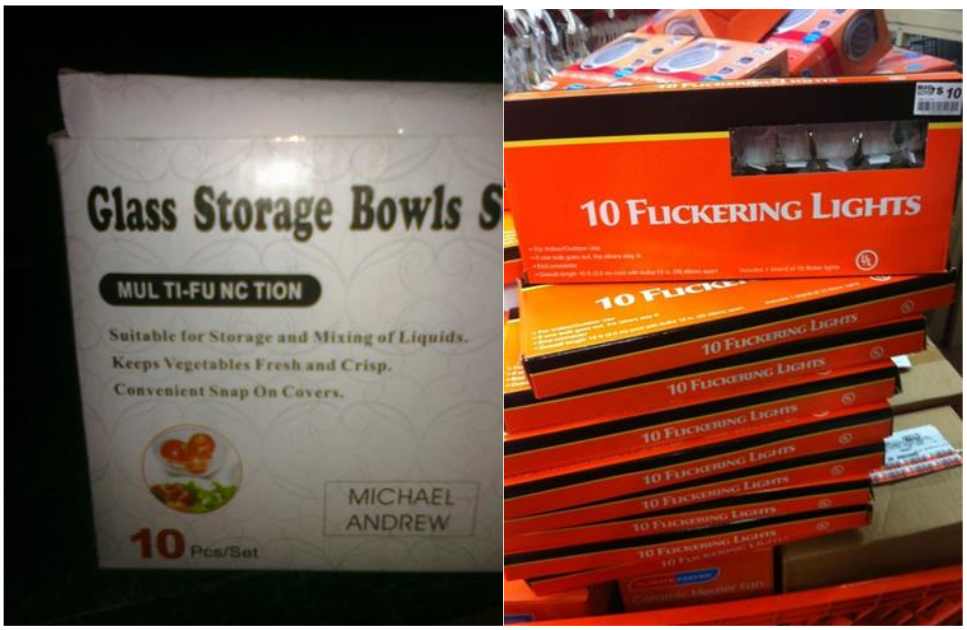
The box of cookies and water bottle on this image clearly stands out but obviously for the wrong reasons. This might be even be a familiar sight for us.

What I do mean by shelf impact is this:

Your design might look amazing on its own, but you need to consider how it will appear next to a multitude of similar products. Notice that all these products make use of the design element colour as well as shape to grab the consumer's attention. Therefore, research about competing products are so important.

The next tip is to consider ***addition.*** Addition links to the process of adding additional products to an existing range of products at a later stage. The added product should still link in with the current range and thus unity and continuity is essential here. Addition can be applied to either a current range or even a follow up rage. Taking the iPhone as an example – continuity has been applied even through the different models. It should be a slow transformation, if there is transformation applied, rather than a quick change. Evolution is key here.

Typography needs to be distinctive and unique but still readable. You have gotten a list of free downloadable typefaces throughout this course but rather make use of premium typefaces that are normally paid for. These typefaces should also have less issues, especially with regards to kerning. Poor kerning can have devastating effects and makes your product look cheap.



Signature colours links to keeping the brand's colours consistent and integrated throughout the packaging design. Successful brands make use of carefully chosen colour pallets and coding (like in using Pantone colours) to differentiate their products. Also remember to consider your colour psychology here and do proper research on the hue and value of the colours you use as well as the connotation they carry.

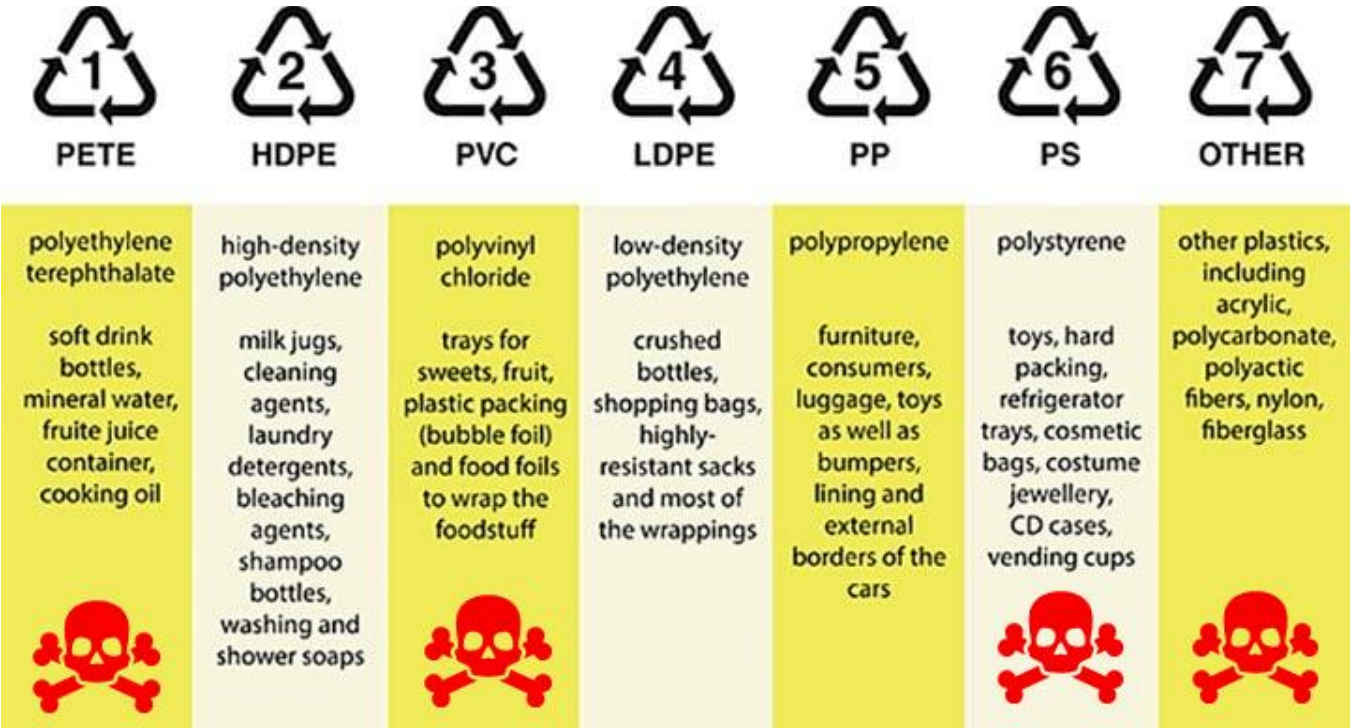
Your company or product ***logo*** should feature prominently along with the product name on your packaging design. This ensure instant recognition and helps build brand trust with your customers. Make sure that if you did not create the logo, that you receive it in vector format when designing your packaging. The quality and display of your logo is of utmost importance.

Size & shape links to the practicality of your packaging design. The shape of your package plays a role, especially considering the primary packaging phase where you will package all the products within a larger container or cardboard box to transport. Both the shape and size will determine how many items you will be able to fit into a primary package so design wisely.

This packaging design looks effective and practical but opening the packaging, which is roughly the size of a post card, you will find a small tablet, the size of a coin inside. Even though this design might look amazing, the mere size if this package makes it not very cost-effective and practical. Perhaps the thought is that due to this being a high-end customer product, that the packaging should live up to that standard but my personal opinion, is that this is a total waste of space.

Most common type of packaging material

The next aspect to consider is the type of container and the material it will be made of. Now, I won't go into too much detail here as packaging technology is a whole different field and this will take ages but at least know the basics.



Types of plastic

- The first type of material we will be looking at is ***plastic.*** Known as one of the most common packaging containers, it is normally made of resin and plastic comes in a variety of different types as well. As mentioned, we can go into so much detail when it comes to the type of material, it's benefits and uses but I will keep it as succinct as possible.

- The first type of plastic material, ***PETE*** is mostly used for water bottles and cooking oil bottles and is intended for single use. Have you ever seen an expiry date on your mineral water bottle? Well, it is there not to show when the water expires because, really, does water expire? But rather to protect its consumer from the toxins that PET give off after a while. This plastic should also not be heated as it melts quickly – which is a sign that it releases toxins quickly as well. It's advantage however is that is commonly recycled and very much recyclable.

- ***HDPE*** is more durable than PET and can be used for milk jugs, cleaning agents, shampoo bottles, toys and so on. It is considered as one of the safest plastics and can withstand extreme temperatures. Of to 120C (or 248F) but also -100C (-148F). This type of packaging is also commonly recycled.

- ***PVC*** is soft and flexible and thus used for food wrapping, credit cards, as well as toys. This plastic is not recyclable but can be repurposed and is also considered toxic. Interestingly, this plastic also never decomposes.

- ***LDPE*** is very common in that it is usually found in squeezable bottles, bread bags, as well as grocery shopping bags. It is quite difficult to recycle and can take anything from 500 to 1000 years to decompose thus plastic recycling programs have been put in place to minimise the use of this. It is also considered to be less toxic than other plastics and considered relatively safe to use.

- One of my favourite plastics, ***PP*** is tough, light-weight and has excellent heat resistance. It is quite common in use and mostly used for ice cream containers, butter containers, potato chip bags, hot food containers, plastic straws and more. It is however one of the lest recycled plastics, but it can be reused. How many of you have butter or ice cream containers that you have been using for quite some time? Well, it is due to PP's features.

- ***PS*** is inexpensive, lightweight and can be moulded easily. It is used for Styrofoam drinking cups and take-away containers, foam packaging and also used as a fill inside shipping containers to protect the contents. It is considered very toxic and should not be heated in a microwave as heat breaks down the toxins. It still baffles me why they use it for food containers. Another factor to consider is that it is not very recycle friendly, unless you are in the business to make cassette tapes.

- Other encapsulates all ***PC*** (poly carbonate) and other plastics that doesn't fall under the first 6. Reusing and recycling procedures are thus not standardised here as it is dependent on the plastic used. Baby bottles, sippy cups, large water bottles, CD's and DVDs are all made of "other" plastics. The toxicity level is difficult to estimate but is believed to leach PBA and PBS unless the plastic however states otherwise. Take heart that a new generation of "other" plastics known as PLA or polylactic acid) made from bio-based polymers are developed. Look for the PLA sign on your container. This type of plastic is also difficult to recycle.

Moving on to ***aluminium*** – which is widely used for canned drinks and food including animal food. It is costly to use and thus recycling programmes are in place. The foil helps to protect products from moisture, sunlight and extreme elements and also used to preserve unopened products.

Aluminium packaging

We will be making a packaging design for a ***paperboard*** item today. This type of packaging is used as a thinner packaging method including labels, bags, large cardboard boxes that normally serve as a primary package. Paperboard has a more complicated manufacturing process whereas cardboard is much simpler since it is usually recycled and does not entail any complicated printing or coatings. This also makes paperboard due to its colouring and coating more difficult to recycle but none the less, both are recyclable.

Paperboard and cardboard packaging

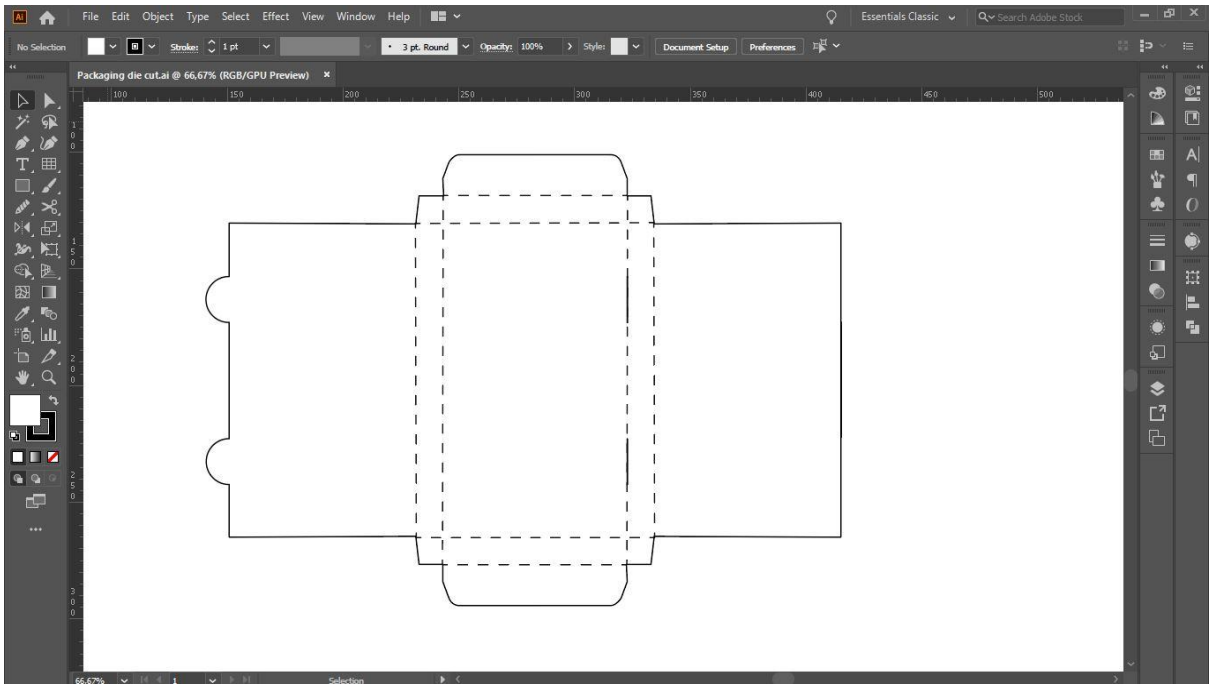
Although ***glass*** is fragile, it is excellent, well-sealed for any perishable product. Alcoholic, non-alcoholic, cosmetics, personal care, food, condiments all are contained in this form of packaging. Glass is preferred by a lot of companies since it is 100% recyclable and reusable. It can actually be recycled continuously without losing quality or purity, unlike plastics. It is normally used for more expensive products and provide a higher quality look and feel than plastic does.

Glass packaging

Paperboard packaging demo

If you are at all interested in becoming a packaging designer, these terms are quite handy, so familiarise yourself with them. Also, I have merely scraped the tip of the iceberg here – there are so much more to know when it comes to packaging and its technologies.

All this theory paid off! I will be creating a paperboard packaging die cut for our demo. There are so many ideas and concepts available online, or even in the comfort of your own home. If you're like me, I like to collect interesting paper board packaging designs as inspiration and also used one of my collected packaging designs as inspiration for this die cut, I will be creating.



Please refer to video demo

Conclusion

I would like to challenge you by creating your very own paperboard package. The tricky part here is to actually print it and make it. Try and use lock tabs to avoid glue and simply do a research on lock tabs to get an idea for your own package. Share your design digitally and if you have a photo of your physically constructed package. I'm excited to see what you will come up with.

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